
FOR SERVICE MEMBERS WITH PCS ORDERS TO ALASKA

The PCS-to-Alaska VA Buyer's Guide.

How to use your VA entitlement to buy a home in Alaska — built for JBER, Eielson, Fort Wainwright, and Coast Guard PCS buyers.

AlaskaVAHomes.com

Derek Huit • NMLS #203980 • 18 Years • \$1B+ Originated • Anchorage, AK
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A NOTE FROM DEREK

First — welcome. You're about to PCS to the most unique duty station in the military. Alaska isn't like moving from Fort Bragg to Fort Hood. The housing market runs on military rhythms, the weather dictates closing timelines, and the property types (dry cabins, permafrost zones, remote septic) will be new to you.

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I've helped hundreds of service members use their VA entitlement to buy up here — JBER PCS arrivals, Eielson aircrew, Fort Wainwright soldiers, Coast Guard transfers, Reserve and Guard, disabled vets, dual military couples. I'm in Anchorage. I know the agents, inspectors, and title companies who know the military buyer.

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This guide is the playbook I give to my own PCS clients when they message me the week their orders drop. Read it on the plane. Highlight what matters to your situation. Then, when you're ready, reach out.

- How to time your VA application with your PCS report date
- Using your BAH to qualify — how Alaska lenders see it

How to use your VA entitlement to buy a home in Alaska — built for JBER, Eielson, Fort Wainwright, and Coast Guard PCS buyers.

- Spouse income, remote-work income, and dual-military strategy

— Derek Huit

Loan Originator | NMLS #203980

Anchorage, Alaska

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TIMELINE

The #1 PCS-VA mistake is starting the mortgage conversation too late. Here's the timeline that works:

FOR

60–90 days out	Application	Full pre-approval. Loan estimate in hand. Start virtual house hunting.
30–60 days out	Under contract	Inspection, appraisal ordered. Remember: AK appraisals run 14–21 days.
14–30 days out	Underwriting	Clear conditions. Signed CD. Set closing for 2–3 days after arrival.
Report date	Arrival	Close. Get keys. Skip the 30-day hotel if timing holds.

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The hotel math.

Every day of temp lodging eats BAH and per-diem differential. A 10-day bridge between arrival and closing is typical and manageable. A 45-day bridge because you started the VA app two weeks before arrival is brutal — and avoidable. Start the loan conversation **the day your orders drop**.

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STEP 1

The **Certificate of Eligibility (COE)** is the VA's document confirming you qualify for a VA home loan and how much entitlement you have. Without it, no VA loan.

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- **Through me.** I request it on your behalf via WebLGY (the VA lender portal). Usually back in 24 hours. Free.

- **Online.** [benefits.va.gov](https://benefits.va.gov/va.gov) or va.gov → login → request. Takes 5–10 business days.

- **By mail.** VA Form 26-1880. Takes 4–8 weeks. Don't do this unless you have to.

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What the COE tells us

- **Eligibility status** — full, partial (already used some), or restored.

- **Entitlement amount** — generally \$36,000 basic + \$113,275 bonus (as of 2026), used as a multiplier for no-down-payment loan limits.

- **Funding fee exemption** — if you have a service-connected disability rating of any percentage, no funding fee. Huge savings.

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Already used your VA entitlement before?

You can still use it again. If the prior VA loan was paid off and you sold the property, **one-time restoration** gives you your full entitlement back. If the prior loan is still active (you kept the house), you may have partial entitlement — still usable for a second VA loan in most cases. I'll pull your COE and explain exactly where you stand.

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STEP 2

This is the part most civilian LOs fumble. Your **Basic Allowance for Housing (BAH)** is qualifying income. It's non-taxable, so for conventional math it gets **grossed up by 25%**, which means a \$2,500/mo BAH counts as \$3,125/mo toward your DTI ratio.

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Rank	JBER / Anchorage (ZIP 995)	Eielson / Fairbanks (ZIP 997)	Juneau / Kodiak
E-5	~\$2,700	~\$2,300	~\$2,100
E-6	~\$2,900	~\$2,500	~\$2,300
E-7	~\$3,200	~\$2,700	~\$2,500
O-3	~\$3,600	~\$3,000	~\$2,900

BAH rates update annually. These are directional — I'll pull your exact rate from your LES.

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- **Base pay.** Straightforward W-2 income from your LES.
- **BAS (subsistence).** Also non-taxable, also grossed up. About \$460/mo for enlisted.
- **Special pays.** Flight, dive, hazardous duty, language, SRB — count if likely to continue. I'll document.
- **Spouse income.** Fully counts. Remote-work income is fine for PCS buyers — two years of history is the standard.
- **VA disability.** Non-taxable, grossed up. Also exempts you from the funding fee.

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STEP 3

VA loans have five major advantages over conventional or FHA financing. Here's each one, with the real-dollar impact on a \$450,000 Alaska home:

Advantage	What it means	Your savings
Zero down payment	0% down vs 5–20% down	\$22,500–\$90,000 cash stays in your pocket
No PMI	No mortgage insurance, ever	~\$250–\$400/mo forever
Seller-paid closing	Seller can pay up to 4% of concession	Up to \$18,000 off your closing costs
Lower rates	VA loans typically rate 0.25–0.5% below conventional	\$70–\$180/mo on a \$400K loan
No funding fee (disabled)	Any service-connected disability rating	\$11,250 saved on 2.15% first-use funding fee

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The only real "cost" of a VA loan is the one-time funding fee, which goes to the VA to keep the program running. For first-time use with zero down, it's 2.15% of the loan amount (2.4% for Reserves/Guard). You can roll it into the loan — no out-of-pocket. And if you have any VA disability rating, you're exempt entirely.

A note on "VA loan limits" in 2026.

If you have full VA entitlement, there is **no loan limit** — you can borrow whatever you qualify for with zero down. The "conforming loan limit" only matters if you have partial entitlement left. Most first-time VA users in Alaska face no limit in practice.

STEP 4

VA loans have property condition standards called **Minimum Property Requirements (MPRs)**. In Alaska, these are stricter than most states because of climate and rural property realities. Here's the list:

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- **Heating.** The home must have a permanent, code-compliant heat source capable of maintaining 50°F in living areas. Wood stove alone = fails. Oil/gas/electric primary = passes.
- **Potable water.** On a well? Must have a current water potability test (within 90 days) and demonstrated flow rate.
- **Wastewater.** Septic must be within code distance from well. Permitted only. On-site septic needs a recent "as-built" certificate from MCA, Mat-Su, FNSB, or KPB.
- **Dry cabins.** Common in Fairbanks/North Pole. No running water = VA will not lend. Period. Be aware shopping interior.
- **Permafrost.** Requires documentation. Foundation settlement issues will kill the loan. Appraiser flags these.
- **Oil tank.** Buried oil tanks are an MPR and environmental issue. Insurance and VA both scrutinize. Must be properly protected.
- **Access.** Home must have year-round road access. Seasonal-access cabins on the Peninsula/Kenai: no-go for VA.

A practical PCS move:

Before you write offers, tell your agent "VA-approved properties only." A good Alaska buyer's agent knows within 30 seconds of looking at a listing whether it'll pass MPRs. This saves you from falling in love with a place the VA won't finance.

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STEP 5

Most PCS buyers can't inspect their new home before arriving in Alaska. You'll fly in, hit temp lodging, and close a few days or weeks later. Here's how to manage that gap:

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- **TLE (CONUS).** Up to 14 days at departure/arrival CONUS duty stations. Alaska is CONUS for TLE purposes — use it.
- **TLE (OCONUS).** Some bases classify as OCONUS. For Alaska, TLE is used at entry points for incoming OCONUS-to-AK transfers via Elmendorf. Check your orders.
- **BAH starts immediately.** The day you report, BAH kicks in — even if you're in temp lodging. That money is yours.
- **Lodging-in-kind.** If installation TLF is full, your command can authorize commercial lodging on receipt. Keep every hotel receipt.

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- **Close before you report.** If your orders allow, close on leave a week before report date. Move in How to use your VA entitlement to buy a home in Alaska — built for JBER, Eielson, Fort Wainwright, and Coast Guard PCS buyers!
- **VA fee rules.** VA fee rules apply to your contract. Sellers in peak season will usually accept.
- **Occupancy clause.** VA requires you to occupy the home within 60 days of closing in most cases. Spouse occupancy counts for active-duty buyers who can't get there yet.
- **Rent-back.** Your seller stays 30 days after close, pays you rent. Works well when your movers have a delay.

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Where you'll be stationed matters for where you should buy. Here's the quick read on each Alaska installation:

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Largest military population in Alaska. Army (USARAK) + Air Force (11th AF). Commute from South Anchorage, Eagle River (20 min), or Wasilla (45–60 min). Strong resale market. Median SFH around \$450K. Best for buyers who want city access + base proximity.

The PCS-to-Alaska

F-35 wing + Red Flag Alaska exercises. 25-minute drive to downtown Fairbanks. Lower home prices (median SFH around \$325K), but longer winters, dry cabin culture in the hills. Best for PCS buyers who prioritize space over urban amenities.

VA Buyer's

Army arctic training. Adjacent to Eielson market but closer to Fairbanks proper. Same home-price tier as Eielson. Watch heating costs carefully — can exceed \$500/mo in winter.

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Specialized markets, limited inventory. Kodiak has the largest CG presence. Juneau has the most normal housing market of the SE Alaska CG posts. USDA eligibility throughout most of these areas — zero down option alongside VA.

THE MONEY

The VA's zero-down loan means you need *far* less cash than most first-time buyers. Here's the real breakdown for a **\$425,000 Alaska** home with VA:

FOR :

Cost Line Item	VA Loan	Conventional (comparison)
Down Payment	\$0	\$21,250 (5%) – \$85,000 (20%)
Funding Fee (first-use, rolled)	Rolled in loan (\$9,140)	N/A
Funding Fee (disabled vet)	\$0 — EXEMPT	N/A
Appraisal	\$725–\$1,200 (VA AK premium)	\$650–\$1,000
Home Inspection	\$500–\$800	\$500–\$800
Title + Settlement	\$2,100–\$4,250	\$2,100–\$4,250
Prepaid Taxes + Insurance	\$3,000–\$6,500	\$3,000–\$6,500
Recording + Transfer	\$200–\$600	\$200–\$600
TOTAL CASH NEEDED	\$6,500–\$13,400*	\$27,750–\$97,000

*Before seller concessions. With 4% seller-paid closing, out-of-pocket can drop to \$0–\$2,000 for a disabled vet.

The VA allows sellers to pay up to **4% of the sales price** in concessions. That's **\$17,000** on a \$425K home. For PCS buyers especially — in slower seasons — this is very achievable. I've had dozens of VA closings where the vet walked in with zero out-of-pocket beyond the earnest money.

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AVOID

#1 — Starting the

FOR SERVICE MEMBERS WITH PCS ORDERS TO ALASKA report date, service member starts house-hunting 30 days out, gets pre-approved 21 days out, closes in temp lodging at day 45. Don't do this. Start **the day your orders are cut**.

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If you have **any** VA service-connected disability rating — even 10% — you're exempt from the funding fee. That's \$9,000+ on a \$425K home. Get your rating confirmed *before* closing, not after.

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CHECKLIST

Print this. Work it top-to-bottom from the day orders arrive.

Task	Target
■ Day 1: Orders arrive — screenshot and file securely	Day 1
■ Day 1: Request Certificate of Eligibility (COE) via lender	Day 1
■ Day 1–3: Pull latest LES + last 2 years W-2s	Week 1
■ Day 1–3: Gather 2 months of bank statements (all pages)	Week 1
■ Day 3–5: Confirm VA disability rating status (for fee exemption)	Week 1
■ Day 3–5: Get pre-approval letter in hand	Week 1
■ Day 5–10: Interview AK buyer's agents who work military clients	Week 2
■ Day 10–20: Virtual tours / submit offers with VA pre-approval	Weeks 2–3
■ Day 20–30: Under contract, inspection + appraisal ordered	Weeks 3–4
■ Day 30–45: Underwriting; respond to conditions within 24hrs	Weeks 4–6
■ Day 40–55: Clear to Close, review Closing Disclosure	Weeks 6–8
■ Day 55–60: Final walkthrough (by proxy if not yet in AK)	Week 8
■ Report Day: Close — sign in AK or via mobile notary pre-travel	Day 60
■ Day 61+: Meet occupancy requirement within 60 days of close	Post-close

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WHY ME

Thousands of LOs can do VA loans on paper. A much smaller number actually do them every week. Here's why a VA-fluent, Alaska-based LO matters for your PCS.

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Alaska has one of the highest military populations per capita in the country. A huge portion of my volume is VA. I work PCS timelines constantly — incoming and outgoing, active and Guard, retiring and separating. I know the forms, the WebLGY portal, and the VA appraisers in Anchorage/Juneau personally.

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Cardinal Financial (NMLS #66247) is a VA-approved direct lender. That means in-house underwriting on VA loans — no correspondent middlemen slowing down your PCS timeline. Their Octane platform keeps you logged in 24/7 via your phone, which matters when you're deployed or TDY.

I'm in Anchorage. When you call at 6pm after work, I'm awake. When you text on a Saturday during a house tour, I'm there. I can help you buy a home in Alaska — built for JBER, Eielson, Fort Wainwright, and Coast Guard PCS buyers.

What PCS clients get from me, guaranteed:

- COE requested within 24 hours of first contact
- Pre-approval letter within 48 business hours
- Text-message response within 1 business hour, 7am–7pm AKT
- Every important thing in writing (email), so your spouse is on the same page
- Referrals to VA-fluent Alaska buyer's agents and military-friendly inspectors

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READY?

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If you're reading this on your phone — the next step is the same: apply. Pre-approval is free, soft-credit, no obligation. You'll have your Certificate of Eligibility in hand in 24 hours.

The PCS to Alaska

V Start your VA application

Soft credit pull. Real pre-approval within 24 business hours. COE requested on your behalf at no cost.

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- **Website:** AlaskaVAHomes.com
- **NMLS Lookup:** nmlsconsumeraccess.org — search #203980
- **Licensing:** cardinalfinancial.com/nmls-licensing

Thank you for your service. Whatever happens from here — whether you work with me or another LO — I hope this guide saved you time, money, and some stress during a busy PCS.

— Derek

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